

Sore-armed ASU faces 'new' UTEP

By DAVE HICKS
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EL PASO — It's difficult to get up in arms over a series in which you've won 14 straight and own a lifetime 29-4 advantage.

But Arizona State's baseball Devils are up to "here" in arm trouble as they open defense of their Western Athletic Conference crown today.

Coach Jim Brock's scheduled starter, sophomore John Poloni (5-0) has developed a sore arm, and reliever Floyd Bannister (3-0) again has tendinitis of the shoulder.

So the Devils (25-13) likely will be without both as they face Texas-El Paso (18-8) in a three-game set that includes a 2 o'clock single game today and a 1 o'clock doubleheader Saturday.

The attrition doesn't quite make A-State an underdog.

In fact, the Devils have made a career of being underdogs against the Miners, who haven't beaten the Arizonans since May 14, 1971.

But Andy Cohen's 1974 edition has broken to an 18-8 getaway — already equaling last year's victory total — and has renewed hopes of at least demanding some attention in the Western AC's Southern Division hassle.

Today's altered mound matchup will send Devil freshman Jim Peterson (7-0) against Roy Stringer (4-0), who set a school record March 30 by striking out 15 batsmen in an 11-2 conquest of Lubbock Christian.

Brock, whose club was 16-1 in the WAC last season en route to a 59-8 finish, now has mapped junior Rick Bethke (2-5) and junior Jim Umbarger (4-1) into Saturday's rotation.

The Miners' best-advertised hitters are third baseman Glenn Villarreal (.400), catcher Jim Brundage (.385), outfielders Joe Pennies (.378) and Herb Von Hagen (.369) and second baseman Mark Miller (.358).

But the UTEP schedule has been somewhat short of awesome.

A-State, winner of the prestigious Riverside, Calif., tourney, owns a .288 team batting mark featuring Bump Wills' .388, eight homers, 47 runs scored and 95 total bases.